

INDIA NATIONAL CYBER THREAT TIMELINE 2026

January-September | Strategic threat assessment, historical recurrence mapping and remediation priorities

9	5	2018-2026	20 Sep 2026
months mapped	espionage-led monthly threats	historical recurrence window	assessment date

Executive judgement

The 2026 pattern is not a sequence of unrelated hacks. Public reporting shows recurring adversary behavior across four strategic themes: government espionage, critical-infrastructure intelligence collection, supply-chain exposure around sensitive projects, and large-scale abuse of trusted digital platforms for fraud or disruption.

Most important finding

The same weaknesses keep reappearing: socially engineered documents, execution through legitimate/signed components, command-and-control hidden inside trusted cloud services, and third-party or identity trust that lets attackers operate without looking obviously malicious. The attacker toolkit changes faster than the underlying defensive gaps.

Highest-priority 2026 cases

JUN	MAY / JUL	JAN / MAR
Mustang Panda - government + hydropower	Kudankulam contractor breach + leak	Pakistan-linked / APT36 government campaigns
Confirmed active beaconing from compromised Indian government systems; Acronis assessed espionage and strategic intelligence collection.	Nuclear-project-related engineering and supplier information exposed through a contractor-hosted environment; core reactor/OT systems were not reported compromised.	Repeated targeted espionage against Indian government systems with new malware, cloud-service C2 and multi-stage lures.

Scope note: this is a public-source strategic assessment of the most consequential documented national-level threat for each month, not a claim that every intrusion was publicly disclosed. Month assignment follows the strongest public disclosure or active observation available.

What changed in 2026 - and what did not

1. Espionage dominates the strategic threat picture.

- January, March, April and June all involve campaigns whose capabilities and targeting are consistent with intelligence collection rather than immediate financial theft.
- APT36/Transparent Tribe or closely aligned Pakistan-linked activity remains persistent against Indian government and defence interests. China-linked espionage activity also returns to strategically important sectors including banking, government and hydropower.
- Legitimate cloud and SaaS services are increasingly used as command-and-control or exfiltration channels, allowing malicious traffic to blend into normal enterprise activity.

2. Supply-chain compromise can be nationally significant even without OT compromise.

The Kudankulam-related leak demonstrates that engineering drawings, supplier lists, meeting notes and support-system information can create security value for an adversary even when reactor-control networks are not breached.

Severity framework used in this report

VERY CRITICAL	Direct government/defence/CII targeting, state-aligned espionage, nuclear/energy exposure, or credible systemic national-security impact.
CRITICAL	Large-scale financial/platform abuse or national disruption with substantial potential impact, but without verified core CII compromise.

Evidence grading

- Official / confirmed: CERT-In, Cyber Swachhta Kendra, PIB/MHA, company disclosure or confirmed incident reporting.
- High-quality threat intelligence: technical research from Zscaler, Acronis, CYFIRMA, Seqrite, Recorded Future, Microsoft and MITRE.
- Claim-dependent: ransomware/hacktivist claims are not treated as fact unless corroborated. July Kudankulam is explicitly marked as the disclosure phase of the May breach.

National context

CERT-In tracked 2,944,248 cybersecurity incidents in 2025, up from 2,041,360 in 2024. Scale alone does not equal national-security severity; this report therefore filters for strategic impact rather than incident volume.

[Government source: PIB / MHA - Assistance to States to Tackle Cyber Incidents \(24 Mar 2026\)](#)

Month-by-month national-level threat table

S.No	Attack / campaign	Month	Severity	Targeting / goal	Threat actor / attribution
1	Gopher Strike + Sheet Attack	Jan	VERY CRITICAL	Indian government compromise and file theft; C2 abused GitHub, Google Sheets/Firebase and Microsoft Graph.	Pakistan-linked APT; Zscaler medium confidence. Possible APT36 subgroup or parallel group.
2	SyncFuture / Blackmoon espionage	Feb	CRITICAL	Income Tax-themed phishing for surveillance, remote access and data exfiltration.	Unattributed; Blackmoon loader + legitimate SyncFuture remote-management tooling.
3	APT36 multi-vector / Datebug campaign	Mar	VERY CRITICAL	Government spear-phishing via ZIP/LNK/PPAM; RAT, remote commands, file manipulation and persistence.	APT36 / Transparent Tribe; researchers describe the group as Pakistan-aligned.
4	LOTUSLITE v1.1 - India banking focus	Apr	VERY CRITICAL	Indian banking-sector espionage; remote shell, file operations and session management.	Mustang Panda cluster; Acronis moderate confidence. Widely tracked as China-linked.
5	Kudankulam contractor environment breach detected	May	VERY CRITICAL	Contractor-hosted environment linked to Units 3/4 project data; nuclear-project supply-chain exposure.	World Leaks later published the data; exact intrusion path remains publicly unclear.
6	Mustang Panda - government + hydropower	Jun	VERY CRITICAL	Hydropower and India-Taiwan intelligence collection; active beaconing from multiple government systems.	Mustang Panda; Acronis high confidence; publicly tracked as China-linked.
7	Kudankulam-related data leak - disclosure phase	Jul	VERY CRITICAL	~19,000 purported files / 14.3 GB leaked. Engineering/supplier material; disclosure phase of May breach.	World Leaks published the data; Reliance confirmed a partial breach.
8	Firebase-hosted bank / government impersonation	Aug	CRITICAL	Bank/PM-KISAN impersonation for financial data, OTP and device-access theft.	Multiple unidentified cybercriminal operators; no credible state attribution.
9	513,847-account Gmail bomb-hoax infrastructure	Sep	CRITICAL	Government/BRICS-period disruption; industrialized creation and resale of account infrastructure.	Criminal network under investigation; two suspects arrested.

Interpretation note: 'VERY CRITICAL' is this report's strategic severity label, not an official CERT-In rating. It reflects potential national-security impact and target sensitivity.

The attacks are different - the weak points repeat



The recurring shift is not only "new malware." Attackers repeatedly hide inside legitimate-looking documents, signed binaries and cloud services.

January-March: Pakistan-linked government espionage + trusted-government lures

JAN | Gopher Strike + Sheet Attack

VERY CRITICAL

Zscaler identified two targeted campaigns against Indian government entities. Delivery was restricted to Windows systems in India; the campaigns abused legitimate cloud services for command-and-control and file theft. Zscaler assessed with medium confidence that the actor was Pakistan-linked and could represent an APT36 subgroup or a parallel group.

Historical mapping

2023: APT36 used ElizaRAT against Indian government targets and abused Google Drive and Telegram. 2024: Operation FlightNight used Slack for exfiltration from Indian government/energy targets. The continuity is clear: trusted cloud services increasingly hide C2/exfiltration traffic.

FEB | SyncFuture / Blackmoon

CRITICAL

Cyber Swachhta Kendra warned of a highly targeted espionage campaign using fake Indian Income Tax notices. The chain used Blackmoon as a loader/persistence mechanism and legitimate, signed SyncFuture remote-management software for covert access.

Historical mapping

2018: CERT-In warned of Income Tax refund SMSing that harvested credentials. 2021: Drinik malware impersonated Income Tax refund workflows and targeted customers of more than 27 Indian banks. The 2026 variant shifts the same trusted-tax theme from fraud toward stealthier persistent access.

MAR | APT36 multi-vector campaign

VERY CRITICAL

CYFIRMA/Broadcom documented a targeted APT36 campaign against Indian government entities using examination-themed ZIPs, deceptive LNK files and macro-enabled PowerPoint add-ins. The payload provided RAT-style remote control, file manipulation and persistence.

Historical mapping

2023: Seqrite documented APT36 targeting the Indian Army using malicious PPAM files to deliver Crimson RAT. 2025: the group adapted its tooling to BOSS Linux used in Indian government environments. 2026 shows further multi-vector redundancy rather than a fundamentally new objective.

Primary links

[Zscaler - Sheet Attack / FIREPOWER / MAILCREEP](#)

[Cyber Swachhta Kendra - SyncFuture / Blackmoon](#)

[CYFIRMA - APT36 multi-vector campaign](#)

[Seqrite - 2023 APT36 Indian Army / PPAM / Crimson RAT](#)

[CERT-In - 2018 Income Tax refund SMSing](#)

[CERT-In - 2021 Drinik Income Tax / banking malware](#)

April-June: strategic-sector espionage and nuclear supply-chain exposure

APR | LOTUSLITE - India banking sector

VERY CRITICAL

Acronis identified a new LOTUSLITE variant themed around India's banking sector. The backdoor supported remote shell access, file operations and session management; Acronis assessed the capability set as espionage-focused and attributed the activity to a Mustang Panda-linked cluster with moderate confidence.

Historical mapping

2021-22: China-linked RedEcho/TAG-38 activity repeatedly targeted Indian electric-grid entities and other critical infrastructure. The strategic-sector focus persists, while the 2026 campaign expands into banking and uses legitimate signed components for DLL sideloading.

MAY | Kudankulam contractor environment breach

VERY CRITICAL

Yotta detected suspicious activity in May on a Reliance-linked server environment associated with project work for Kudankulam Units 3/4. Reliance later confirmed a partial breach. Public reporting did not show compromise of core reactor-control systems.

Historical mapping

2019: NPCIL confirmed malware on a Kudankulam administrative-network computer; later analysis linked the infection to DTrack. The ICS was reported unaffected. The repeated lesson is that non-OT systems around nuclear facilities still hold data and credentials valuable to adversaries.

JUN | Mustang Panda - government + hydropower

VERY CRITICAL

Acronis documented two campaigns against Indian government/hydropower targets using SHARDLOADER, MINIRECON and ZOHOMURK. ZOHOMURK abused Zoho WorkDrive for C2 and exfiltration. Acronis observed active beaconing from multiple compromised government systems between 12-22 June and worked with CERT-In.

Historical mapping

2021: RedEcho targeted 10 Indian power-sector organizations. 2022: TAG-38 activity targeted at least seven State Load Despatch Centres. In 2026, the energy-interest pattern returns with cloud-based C2 and hydropower/Taiwan-themed intelligence objectives.

Primary links

[Acronis - LOTUSLITE variant targeting India banking](#)

[Reuters - Kudankulam-related files exposed after contractor-side breach](#)

[Acronis - Mustang Panda targeting India government + hydropower](#)

[MITRE ATT&CK - Indian Critical Infrastructure Intrusions 2021-22](#)

[Kaspersky ICS CERT - 2019 Kudankulam DTrack/admin-network incident](#)

July-September: leak consequences, platform-scale fraud and disruption infrastructure

JUL | Kudankulam data-leak disclosure phase

VERY CRITICAL

World Leaks published roughly 19,000 purported files totaling 14.3 GB related to the Units 3/4 project, including engineering, supplier and infrastructure material. This is the public disclosure phase of the May breach, not a second intrusion.

Historical mapping

2019 showed the danger of malware on a nuclear facility's administrative network; 2026 shows a second path: contractor and project-data exposure. Both cases underline the importance of protecting the surrounding information ecosystem, not only OT.

AUG | Firebase-hosted banking/government impersonation

CRITICAL

I4C identified at least 57 Firebase-hosted sites/databases in August used to distribute malware or collect stolen financial data. Lures impersonated SBI, ICICI, Axis and PM-KISAN. Reuters reported the wider government action sought removal of hundreds of Firebase accounts.

Historical mapping

2021: Drinik targeted 27+ Indian banks through a fake Income Tax app. 2023: Microsoft documented WhatsApp-distributed APKs impersonating Indian banks/KYC. 2024: DoT acted on malicious electricity-KYC APK campaigns. The 2026 shift is backend scale: fraud infrastructure is increasingly hosted on trusted cloud platforms.

SEP | 513,847 Gmail-account bomb-hoax infrastructure

CRITICAL

Gujarat Police uncovered credentials for 513,847 Gmail accounts in an investigation into hoax bomb threats to government offices. Reuters reported threats that intersected with the BRICS summit security environment; the network had operated since 2022.

Historical mapping

2024: more than 50 Delhi/NCR schools were evacuated after mass email threats, and government data recorded 999 hoax bomb threats to aircraft/airports by 14 Nov 2024. The 2026 case suggests industrialization of the enabling account infrastructure rather than a new tactic.

Primary links

[Reuters - Kudankulam-related leak](#)

[Reuters - India orders Firebase takedowns after scam pattern](#)

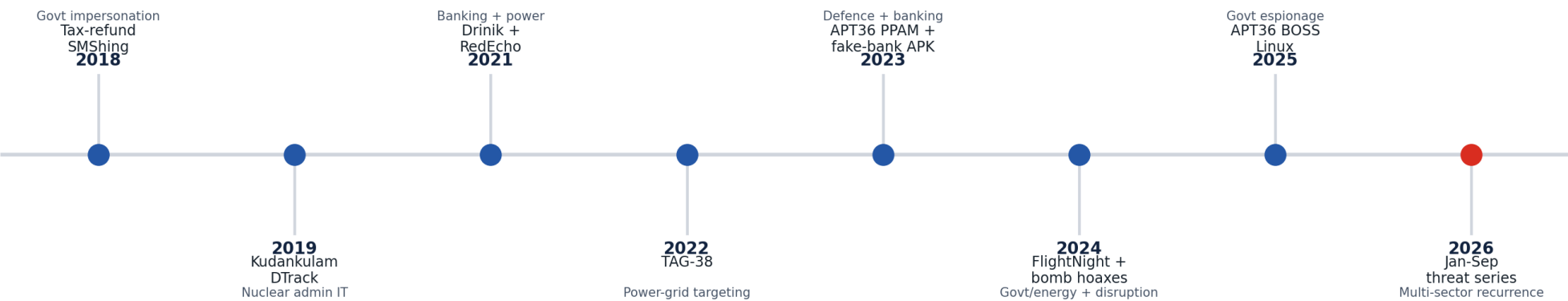
[Microsoft - 2023 Android banking trojans targeting Indian users](#)

[Reuters - 513,847 Gmail IDs linked to bomb-hoax network](#)

[Rajya Sabha - 1,148 aircraft/airport hoax threats since Aug 2022; 999 in 2024 to Nov 14](#)

2018-2026: attacks evolve; strategic objectives persist

Historical recurrence: the 2026 threats are evolutions of older patterns



Year	Representative event	Core pattern	Why it matters for 2026
2018	Income Tax refund SMSHING	Tax authority impersonation + phishing pages	Precursor to 2026 Blackmoon trusted-government lure.
2019	Kudankulam administrative-network DTrack infection	Nuclear-sector IT reconnaissance / data collection	Direct precedent for protecting non-OT systems around nuclear infrastructure.
2021	Drinik + RedEcho	Banking malware + power-grid targeting	Two durable patterns: mass financial malware and strategic-energy reconnaissance.
2022	TAG-38 Indian power-grid intrusions	Critical-infrastructure intelligence / possible pre-positioning	Continuity of strategic interest in electricity and control-adjacent networks.
2023	APT36 PPAM / Crimson RAT; fake bank APKs	Defence espionage + banking credential theft	Delivery vectors used again in evolved form in 2026.
2024	Operation FlightNight; mass bomb-hoax wave	Cloud-service exfiltration + national disruption	Direct behavioral precursors to 2026 cloud-C2 espionage and hoax-account infrastructure.
2025	APT36 targeting BOSS Linux	Government espionage adapted to indigenous Linux environments	Shows actor persistence and platform-specific adaptation before 2026.
2026	Cloud C2 + supply-chain leak + platform abuse	Espionage, extortion, fraud and disruption converge	Trusted services and third parties become the dominant hiding layer.

Five recurring lessons for national cyber defence

1

Legitimate services are becoming attacker infrastructure

Google Sheets, Firebase, Graph API, Zoho WorkDrive, Slack and signed binaries recur because blocking them outright is operationally difficult. Detection must focus on who/what process is using the service, not merely whether the domain is reputable.

2

Government phishing remains strategically effective

APT36-style lures succeed by using realistic policy, examination, defence or administrative themes. The defensive gap is as much document execution policy and endpoint behavior as user awareness.

3

Critical infrastructure risk extends beyond OT

Kudankulam 2019 and 2026 both demonstrate that administrative networks, contractors, engineering repositories and suppliers can expose intelligence useful for reconnaissance or follow-on attacks even when OT remains uncompromised.

4

Sector switching is normal for mature espionage actors

China-linked activity has appeared against power, government, policy and now banking/hydropower targets. Defence based only on historical victim sectors will miss strategic pivots.

5

Digital-platform scale turns local fraud/disruption into national risk

Firebase abuse and the Gmail hoax-account network show how inexpensive cloud/account infrastructure can industrialize campaigns that would previously require much more operational effort.

MEA-oriented implication: cyber incidents increasingly intersect with diplomacy, bilateral tensions, technology dependencies and trusted commercial platforms. Ask not only "who was hacked?" but what strategic information, leverage or signalling value the access could create.

Priority defensive actions: from endpoint controls to national coordination

0-30 DAYS | CLOSE THE EASY PATHS

- Block or tightly control LNK, PPAM, VBS, ISO and executable archives from external mail where business use is not required.
- Enforce phishing-resistant MFA for privileged/government accounts and remove shared administrative identities.
- Deploy EDR detections for DLL sideloading, mshta/PowerShell misuse, unusual signed-binary execution and suspicious archive chains.
- Inventory sanctioned cloud/SaaS services; alert when non-browser processes or unusual service accounts access APIs such as WorkDrive, Graph, Sheets or Firebase.
- Validate immutable/offline backups and isolate backup credentials from production identity.

30-90 DAYS | LIMIT BLAST RADIUS

- Apply application control / allow-listing to government and CII endpoints; require signed/approved software paths.
- Segment contractor, administrative, IT and OT environments; make vendor access time-bound, identity-bound and device-verified.
- Classify engineering/project data and deploy DLP on repositories containing diagrams, supplier lists, credentials and operational documentation.
- Build behavioral detections across identity + endpoint + SaaS telemetry so trusted-domain traffic is not automatically trusted.
- Create sector-specific hunt packages for APT36 and Mustang Panda TTPs; share via CERT-In/CyMAC/NCIIPC channels.

90-180 DAYS | BUILD NATIONAL RESILIENCE

- Mandate minimum cyber-security clauses for contractors working on CII/nuclear/defence projects, including breach notification, logging and data-minimization requirements.
- Establish rapid cloud-platform abuse/takedown playbooks with major providers for phishing, malware backends and bulk malicious-account infrastructure.
- Run joint tabletop exercises that combine technical incident response, public communication, law enforcement and diplomatic/national-security escalation.
- Measure mean time to detect and contain cloud-service C2, credential misuse and vendor compromise - not only malware detection.
- Require continuous validation that CII compromise cannot pivot from enterprise IT or contractors into operational systems.

Controls matched to 2026 threat patterns

Threat pattern	Priority controls
APT36 / govt phishing	Secure email gateway + sandboxing; disable high-risk document execution; AppLocker/WDAC; EDR; phishing-resistant MFA; cloud-C2 behavior analytics.
Mustang Panda / strategic espionage	DLL sideloading detections; egress analytics; cloud-API telemetry; strict service-account controls; threat hunting for geopolitical lure themes.
Nuclear / energy supply chain	Vendor segmentation; project-data classification; encrypted repositories; DLP; time-bound vendor identities; OT/IT separation validation.
Firebase / mobile banking fraud	Official-app-only policy; MDM/Play Protect; APK sideload restrictions; brand/domain monitoring; rapid takedown; transaction anomaly controls.
Bomb-hoax / account infrastructure	Platform-level account-risk scoring; bulk-account abuse detection; threat-intake triage; law-enforcement/platform coordination; resilient continuity plans.

Primary and high-authority sources - clickable

Links below are the sources used to verify the monthly incidents, attribution claims and historical parallels. Threat-actor attribution is stated at the confidence level of the cited research rather than presented as independently proven fact.

[2026 Jan - Zscaler: SHEETCREEP / FIREPOWER / MAILCREEP targeting Indian government](#)

[2026 Feb - Cyber Swachhta Kendra: SyncFuture espionage / Blackmoon](#)

[2026 Mar - Broadcom/Symantec: Datebug campaign](#)

[2026 May/Jul - Reuters: Kudankulam-related project files exposed](#)

[2026 Aug - Reuters: Firebase abuse in Indian banking scams](#)

[India context - PIB/MHA: CERT-In incident counts](#)

[Historical - CERT-In 2018 Income Tax refund SMSing](#)

[Historical - Kaspersky ICS CERT: 2019 Kudankulam administrative-network infection](#)

[Historical - Recorded Future: continued power-grid targeting / TAG-38 \(2022\)](#)

[Historical - Seqrite: 2023 APT36 Indian Army / PPAM / Crimson RAT](#)

[Historical - Microsoft: 2023 fake Indian banking APK / WhatsApp campaigns](#)

[Historical - Reuters: May 2024 mass bomb-hoax emails to Delhi/NCR schools](#)

[Historical - CYFIRMA: 2025 APT36 targeting BOSS Linux government environments](#)

[2026 supporting - PIB/I4C: Boss Scam targeting executives/finance](#)

[2026 Jan - Zscaler monthly roundup: Gopher Strike + Sheet Attack attribution context](#)

[2026 Mar - CYFIRMA: APT36 multi-vector campaign](#)

[2026 Apr - Acronis: LOTUSLITE variant and India banking focus](#)

[2026 Jun - Acronis: Mustang Panda India government/hydropower campaigns](#)

[2026 Sep - Reuters: 513,847 Gmail IDs linked to bomb-hoax investigation](#)

[National coordination - MHA: Cyber Multi Agency Centre \(CyMAC\)](#)

[Historical - CERT-In 2021 Drinik malware targeting 27+ Indian banks](#)

[Historical - Recorded Future: RedEcho targeting Indian power sector \(2021\)](#)

[Historical - MITRE ATT&CK: Indian Critical Infrastructure Intrusions C0043](#)

[Historical - Zscaler: 2023 APT36 ElizaRAT / Google Drive / Telegram](#)

[Historical - DSCI India Cyber Threat Report: 2024 Operation FlightNight](#)

[Historical - Rajya Sabha: 999 aircraft/airport bomb threats in 2024 to Nov 14](#)

[2026 supporting - CERT-In: RTO/eChallan Android malware](#)

Prepared from publicly available sources through 20 September 2026. Absence from this report does not prove absence of an incident; government and private-sector intrusions may remain undisclosed.